Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “gold = this”, and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made up of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we have lived through ourselves**.

From the body

Gold is the colour of **the sun, honey and autumn light**. The eye catches it quickly because it shines and changes. That helps explain why gold can have a relationship to worth and to attention.

From culture

In most of the world gold is linked with **worth, power and celebration**. A medal, a crown, a ring, a halo. At the same time it can mean ostentation and greed. In the chapter on cultures we will look at this in more detail.

From what you have lived

Grandmother's gold chain, the gold paper on a chocolate, wallpaper from the seventies, a first gold ring. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same gold** and one feels warmth, the other ostentation.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is actually “gold” and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does gold connect with first for me and where do I know that from?**

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Stories

Gold has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where begins what people make of it.

The gold mask

The tomb of Tutankhamun was discovered in **1922** and the gold funerary mask was uncovered in 1925, when researchers opened the innermost of the coffins. It weighs roughly ten kilograms of gold and is inlaid with lapis lazuli, carnelian and glass.

In the Egyptian image gold is a sign of the divine body, which is not subject to time. Gold here is not wealth for show. It is **an image of something meant to last**.

El Dorado

The legend of the golden king arose in the records of Spanish conquerors in the 16th century. It speaks of a ruler who covered himself in gold dust and washed it off in a sacred lake. Later versions relate it to Lake Guatavita and the anointing of a new ruler of the Muisca people.

In **1969** a gold miniature of a vessel with a seated figure and attendants was found, today in the Museo del Oro in Bogotá. Historians argue about how much of the story is reality and how much the Spaniards added. Gold became **a promise that led people further than beyond the edge of a map**.

Gold that joins

Kintsugi is the Japanese technique of repairing broken ceramics with urushi lacquer and powder of gold, silver or platinum. The seams are not hidden but highlighted. According to one theory it is connected with the 15th century and the shogun Ashikaga Yoshimasa.

The technique is close to the idea of wabi-sabi, that is, the acceptance of imperfection. Gold here is not a symbol of perfection. It is **a visible trace of the fact that something was repaired**.

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